the slightest excuse. They were also sworn to ethical practices, a personality trait that JRD publicly appreciated in the younger Tata.

Some even argued that JRD had always wanted to appoint a Tata. Though he had not made any statement that could fuel such thoughts, he had in 1988 revealed that in the case of senior appointments, all other things being equal, a Tata surname would be an advantage. However, JRD had also said in an interview in 1991: ‘He [Ratan] is not a blood relation; things like that do not matter to me.’

While all these factors may have weighed in favour of the young Tata, observers missed the most important factor: Ratan’s Strategic Plan that revealed his long-term vision to help the group retain its position as the foremost industrial house in the country. Ratan was seen as a young and educated leader with the vision to lead the group. As Koushik Chatterjee, who worked closely with Ratan after he became chairman, Tata Sons, would say many years later, ‘Ratan is an ideation factory.’

The initiative Ratan had taken to write to JRD on the urgent issues that the group needed to address had resonated with the chairman in no small measure. It was evident in his acceptance of almost all the suggestions Ratan had made. The initiative Ratan had taken was to prevent the group from losing its cohesion and give the Tatas a vision for the next ten years. The question before JRD was who would be most suitable to achieve this much-needed transformation.

JRD laid all speculation to rest when, in an interview with a leading magazine in 1986, he revealed that he had chosen Ratan to replace him because of his long-term vision and his highly perceptive mind. Unknown to the outside world, JRD was closely watching Ratan’s performance and evincing great interest in his career. In a handwritten letter in December 1979, JRD had expressed his ‘affection’ for Ratan and said that he was ‘very interested’ in the younger Tata’s ‘career’. Alluding to the Strategic Plan, he remarked that Ratan was a ‘young man with a young mind’ who had proposed to him (JRD) that the group enter new areas of business. The chairman recalled Ratan telling him: ‘Let’s make use of Tata Industries, let’s sponsor new industries. It bears a good name, it’s a good instrument.’ JRD revealed that he had concurred with the proposal and told Ratan: ‘Yes, you go ahead and be chairman of it.’

Ratan’s appointment as chairman of TIL was a defining moment in the group’s history. It was the first time that a chairman was selected primarily